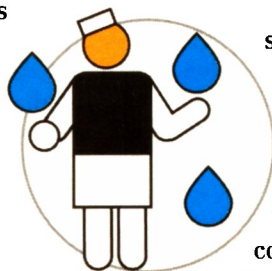


You could argue that given the enormity of the water crisis, it is necessary to have a Central ministry to create policy and monitor implementation. But the track record of the Water Resources Ministry doesn't inspire confidence. The crux of the matter is that water management, or rather mismanagement, involves nine ministries—Water Resources, Rural Development, Panchayati Raj, Urban Development, Food, Agriculture, Health, Power and Environment—and consensus is an elusive goal. So nothing quite gets done. Nearly 60 years after Independence, over two-thirds of the cultivable land continues to be vulnerable to the vagaries of the monsoon. A recent report reveals that 159 major projects, 251 medium-scale projects and 94 renovation works have been pending since the 1960s. In fact, for nearly three decades the ministry has failed to come to a conclusion whether inter-linking of rivers across India is a good idea or not.

In reply to a question in the Lok Sabha on the inadequate irrigation facilities, Minister for Water Resources Saifuddin Soz said, "Irrigation being a state subject, projects are conceived, planned and implemented by the state governments as per their own priority." As early as in 1919, irrigation was deemed a provincial subject and the responsibility of the Government of India was confined to advice. In other

words, there is little the Centre can do beyond coaxing the states. The much-vaunted Accelerated Irrigation Benefit Programme, for instance, is a classic carrot-and-stick scheme where states are "rewarded" for better performance in completing irrigation projects. The same is the case with drinking water supply. Barely a third of the rural populace has access to water on tap. A study of 12 major cities revealed that the shortfall in water supply is 4,000 million litre a day, which is what Mumbai needs every day, or in volume terms, water enough to fill 4 lakh big water tankers.



Even in terms of resolving inter-state water-sharing conflicts, the record is hardly satisfactory. The track record of the Eradi Commission set up for resolving disputes between Punjab and Haryana in 1985, or the annual flare-up of the Cauvery dispute, is testimony to the powerlessness of the Centre. The hard fact is that the administrative control and responsibility for development of water rests with state governments—be it irrigation projects, drinking water supply or even hydro power, which is the responsibility of state electricity boards. Sure the Ministry of Water Resources does a splendid job in terms of collating national data, scenario reports and evangelism. But does every evangelist need a ministry?

between 15 to 20 ministries, unlike the ever-expanding ministerial structure of India

UNITED KINGDOM

The British Government has a council of 19 ministers led by the prime minister

- Prime Minister
- Deputy Prime Minister
- Chancellor of Exchequer
- Leaders of both Houses of Parliament
- Secretary of State for Foreign and Commonwealth Affairs
- Secretary of State for Trade and Industry
- Secretary of State for the Home Department
- Secretary of State for Health
- Secretary of State for Culture, Media and Sport
- Cabinet Office Minister and for Social Exclusion
- Secretary of State for Northern Ireland, and Secretary of State for Wales
- Lord Chancellor, Secretary of State for Justice
- Secretary of State for International Development
- Secretary of State for Education and Skills
- Secretary of State for Communities and Local Government
- Secretary of State for Work and Pensions
- Secretary of State for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs
- Secretary of State for Defence
- Secretary of State for Transport and State for Scotland

FRANCE

The French Government is led by the president assisted by the prime minister and his cabinet of 15 ministers and four state secretaries (ss) besides a High Commissioner

- Ecology, Sustainable Planning and Development
- Economy, Finance and Employment
- Interior, Overseas and Local Authorities
- Foreign and European Affairs
- Immigration, Integration, National Identity
- Justice
- Labour, Industrial Relations and Solidarity
- Education
- Higher Education and Research
- Defence
- Health, Youth and Sport
- Housing and Cities
- Agriculture and Fisheries
- Culture and Communications
- Budget, Public Accounts and Civil Service
- SS in charge of Relations with the Parliament
- SS of Forecasting and Public Policy Assessment
- SS in charge of Transport
- SS in charge of European Affairs
- High Commissioner on Active Solidarity against Poverty